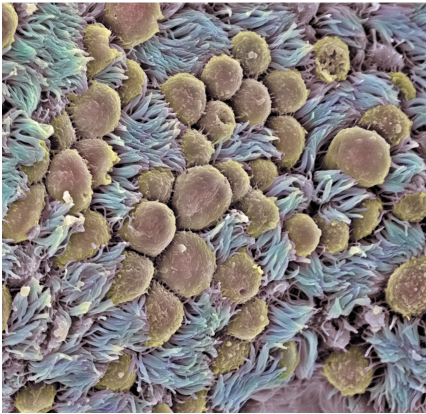




THIS IS **DAY 11 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
269 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

The lining of the fallopian tube, seen here, has a moist mucous membrane. This contains cells (brown) that protect the tube's surface. The hairlike cilia (blue) move the eggs along the tubes following ovulation.

“ If this isn't the first month you've been trying to conceive, don't be too disappointed. It's normal for it to take some time. ”

Have you been trying for a baby for some time? Not being able to conceive when you want to can be difficult to handle, especially if you're someone who has achieved in other areas of your life.

With reproduction, there's a large element of chance. Even for young women at their peak of fertility, the odds of conceiving in any one cycle are 20–30 percent. It's not unusual to try for six months, or even 12 months, without success. Around 10–15 percent of couples can take over a year to achieve a pregnancy or find it difficult to conceive. So plan for conception over a longer time frame, say 12 months, unless you have any specific reasons to be concerned about your fertility or your health in general.

The main exceptions are if you are over 35 or have a known fertility problem or gynecological issue. In this case, see your doctor after trying for about six months. The first step is likely to be a blood test for you, and a semen analysis for your partner. Rest assured that you may still get pregnant the old-fashioned way, but you have to be more proactive if you are in this older age group. The hitch is that if you do end up needing assisted fertility techniques, it all takes time.

ASK A NUTRITIONIST

Why can't I take supplements that contain vitamin A? The plant version of vitamin A, called beta-carotene, is safe to eat. It is found in orange, yellow, red, and dark green vegetables and fruits. The animal form, retinol, is found in eggs, butter, and meats, and it is six times more potent. A healthy diet should contain all the vitamin A you need in pregnancy. Too high doses have been associated with abnormalities developing in the brain and heart of the baby and linked to miscarriage. Take only multivitamin preparations recommended for pregnancy. These contain carotenoids, which are the precursor to vitamin A and can be converted into vitamin A by the body as needed.

STOPPING CONTRACEPTION

You can get pregnant as soon as you stop using some contraception.